

Conversations About Attention, Stillness, and Freedom

To Super Xiaobao bei,

I am sharing this conversation with you exactly as it unfolded. It is not a polished essay or a set of instructions. It is a record of me thinking aloud—questioning old assumptions, testing new ideas, and trying to understand how best to protect my attention, peace, health, time, and freedom.

Some thoughts are strong because they were written in moments of strong feeling. You do not need to agree with every word or adopt every conclusion. Keep only what is useful to you.

What I hope you will see beneath the conversation is something simple: your worth does not depend on anyone's approval. Your attention is precious. Your body deserves care. Your time and money should support your freedom. Your inner life belongs to you.

I share this not because I want you to think exactly as I do, but because I want you to know what I have learned—and perhaps find something here that helps you build your own peaceful and independent life.

With love,

Mom

Disclaimer: These conversations capture my thoughts in motion. My understanding continues to evolve, and no single statement should be treated as my final conclusion. I am testing ideas, refining principles, and searching for mental shortcuts that help me return quickly to stillness.

My ultimate goal is to become unbothered and unshakable; to enjoy my own company; and to direct my attention, time, money, and energy toward growth, freedom, and optionality. I owe that commitment to myself.

You do not need to agree with every thought or adopt every conclusion. Keep only what is useful to you, and continue developing principles of your own.

Me: What does stillness really mean?

ChatGPT: Stillness does not mean having no thoughts, feelings, desires, or reactions. It means **remaining internally centered while they pass through you.**

You may feel irritated, frightened, lonely, excited, or drawn toward something—but you do not immediately speak, spend, explain, defend, retaliate, or seek reassurance. You notice the feeling without allowing it to command your next action.

Stillness has several parts:

- **A pause between stimulus and response.**
- **Freedom from the need to prove, explain, or correct yourself immediately.**
- **Attention returning to what you deliberately choose.**
- **The ability to experience emotion without converting it into impulsive behavior.**
- **Comfort in your own company, without needing external activity or approval to confirm your worth.**

Stillness is therefore not passivity. You may decide to speak firmly, leave, correct a problem, spend money, or take action. The difference is that the action comes from judgment—not agitation.

A concise definition for your document could be:

Stillness is the inner space in which I notice what I feel, remain centered, and choose my response deliberately.

Or your mental shortcut:

Return to stillness: nothing requires an immediate reaction.

That is the heart of becoming “unbotherable.” It does not mean nothing ever touches you. It means what touches you does not automatically direct you.

Me: like I am a mountain?

ChatGPT: Yes—like a mountain.

Weather moves across it: wind, rain, snow, heat, and clouds. The mountain experiences all of it, but does not chase the weather or become the weather.

Your thoughts and emotions are weather. **You are the mountain.**

I remain like a mountain. Feelings pass through me like weather. I observe them, process them, and choose my actions from stillness.

Being a mountain does not mean being cold or motionless. It means being grounded. You can still adapt, grow, leave, speak, and act—but not because someone else created a storm.

A shorter mental shortcut:

Weather passes. The mountain remains.

Me: Attention is everything. Sometimes my mind wanders, and it is really important for me not to let that happen. What I have found is that when I have plenty to do—when I keep myself occupied with meaningful tasks, even watering the plants—I can pull my wandering mind back.

My Georgia Tech and Boston University courses have really helped. Even though I have used an AI-assisted approach to learning, I still have some valuable takeaways. In the end, these takeaways—even just two or three—could “save my life” to some extent.

I think I want to study law, perhaps earn a law degree, and explore history, poetry, photography, or anything else that could help me achieve greater inner peace.

ChatGPT: Yes. What you are describing is not merely “staying busy.” It is **giving attention a deliberate place to go**.

A wandering mind becomes costly when it repeatedly returns to comparison, workplace politics, old interactions, imagined motives, or things outside your control. Meaningful tasks interrupt that loop because they restore agency: watering the plants, repairing code, studying one legal principle, reading one poem, editing one photograph. Each action says, *my attention belongs to me, and I decide where it goes*.

GT and BU did not need to make you remember every concept to be valuable. If each course leaves you with only two or three durable principles that improve your judgment, those principles compound over decades. The deeper benefit is that you have practiced:

- Learning unfamiliar material quickly.
- Continuing despite imperfect grades or difficult circumstances.
- Using AI as leverage while retaining judgment.
- Converting abstract ideas into personal operating rules.
- Returning your mind to a chosen objective.

Those abilities can indeed “save your life” in the broader sense: they protect your independence, earning power, adaptability, and emotional stability.

I would not immediately commit to another expensive degree simply to occupy the mind. A law degree is demanding, credential-oriented, and often adversarial. Law itself, however, could be deeply useful to you—contracts, evidence, negotiation, privacy, administrative procedure, and institutional power. You can study those subjects without first assuming the burden of becoming a lawyer.

History, poetry, and photography serve different parts of you:

- **Law** sharpens boundaries, rights, evidence, and strategic reasoning.
- **History** enlarges perspective and shows that today’s people and conflicts are recurring patterns.
- **Poetry** concentrates attention and gives precise language to inner experience.

- **Photography** trains presence: light, composition, place, and your own existence within the scene.

For greater inner peace, I would combine them rather than choose only one:

One serious subject for the intellect, one art for the inner life, and one physical practice that returns you to the present.

For you, that might be **law/history + poetry/photography + gardening/walking**.

The important rule is not “never let my mind wander.” Some wandering produces imagination and insight. The better rule is:

When my mind wanders somewhere that diminishes me, I return it to something I have chosen.

You do not need to control every thought. You need to control what receives continued attention.

Me: I almost didn’t sign up for my summer courses because I was traveling to places without reliable internet access, but signing up turned out to be the best decision. I decided that, in the worst-case scenario, I could retake the courses, since the tuition was relatively affordable. Frankly, I do not really care about grades because directing my attention toward the right things is priceless.

I thought I might not have time for those courses, but who would have thought that AI tools would make all the homework a breeze?

ChatGPT: That decision was more valuable than the grades. You recognized an important asymmetry:

- The downside was limited: affordable tuition, inconvenience, perhaps retaking a course.
- The upside was enormous: structure, intellectual engagement, progress toward degrees, and protection of your attention during extensive travel.

You purchased an **environment for your mind**. The assignments gave your attention somewhere constructive to return to instead of allowing uncertainty, workplace politics, travel disruptions, or repetitive thoughts to occupy it.

AI changed the practical equation. It reduced the friction of understanding instructions, debugging, organizing material, and producing drafts. That did not make the courses meaningless. It moved your effort away from mechanical struggle and toward:

- Identifying the real problem.
- Evaluating whether an answer is correct.
- Selecting and applying useful concepts.

- Persisting through unfamiliar material.
- Learning how to direct a powerful tool.

The one thing to protect is the distinction between **completion and absorption**. AI can make homework feel effortless, but you still want each course to leave behind two or three principles that genuinely belong to you. That is enough. After completing a course, ask:

1. What changed the way I think?
2. What can I now recognize that I could not recognize before?
3. What rule or capability will I carry forward?

Your larger realization is excellent:

I do not evaluate education only by grades or credentials. I evaluate it by whether it directs my attention toward something that expands my life.

You nearly declined the courses because you predicted insufficient time and connectivity. Instead, you created optionality, accepted the manageable worst case, and discovered new leverage through AI. That is exactly the adaptive capability you said you want to preserve.

Me: What has changed the way I think? My most important takeaways from my MBA program and Georgia Tech's Online Master of Science in Cybersecurity program are:

Those business professors never pay taxes when purchasing or selling houses. Never operate within other people's frames.

From cybersecurity: adopt zero trust and always verify. Any leak could cost an enormous amount.

From my Arctic travels with my cabinmate: never reveal my emotional buttons. She was surprisingly observant. Because I am still learning to master my emotions, I became a little "irritated." That was one of my most valuable lessons: whatever people say or do to me, I should ask what their incentives or motives are. Never show my hand or reveal my emotions, especially the things that bother me.

Never share my evaluation of others or my opinions about someone.

ChatGPT: These lessons form one coherent philosophy: **protect attention, information, and optionality**.

I would refine them into rules that are strong without forcing you into constant suspicion:

1. **Identify the frame before entering it.**
Ask: Who defined the question? What outcome does this framing favor? Do I need to respond at all?

2. **Consider incentives without automatically assuming malice.**

Ask: What does this person gain—attention, information, status, agreement, emotional reaction, or control? Incentives explain behavior more reliably than stated intentions.

3. **Pause before revealing a reaction.**

Irritation is information. Process it privately before deciding whether the other person should receive that information. Useful neutral responses include:

- “Interesting.”
- “I’ll think about that.”
- “Perhaps.”
- “I don’t have an opinion on that.”
- “What makes you ask?”

4. **Use zero trust for consequential matters.**

Trust is not a permanent label placed on a person. Verify claims, permissions, transactions, access, and commitments according to their potential cost. The higher the consequence, the stronger the verification.

5. **Disclose by purpose and need.**

Before sharing, ask: Why does this person need to know? What benefit does disclosure create for me or for a legitimate shared objective? Information cannot be retrieved once released.

6. **Do not casually evaluate other people.**

Opinions travel, mutate, and can later be attributed to you. Discuss observable facts and work outcomes when necessary; avoid sharing character judgments, alliances, dislikes, or private assessments.

7. **Manage emotion rather than suppressing it.**

The goal is not to become unreadable or emotionless. It is to prevent an unprocessed feeling from choosing your behavior. You may feel irritated; the strategic achievement is that irritation does not automatically become speech or action.

8. **Structure transactions before executing them.**

Your professors probably did not literally “never pay taxes.” They likely used lawful exclusions, deductions, exchanges, timing, and ownership structures. The broader lesson is excellent: understand the rules before acting because structure can radically change the outcome.

Your cabin-mate experience was valuable because it exposed a vulnerability in a relatively low-stakes environment. The lesson is not that nobody should ever know you. It is:

Access to my inner life is earned; reactions are processed before they are disclosed; consequential claims are verified.

And perhaps the most important rule:

Never let another person choose the object of my attention merely by discovering what provokes me.

Me: Never let anyone access my inner life. My inner life belongs to me alone

ChatGPT: Yes—your inner life belongs to you. No one is automatically entitled to your fears, hopes, irritations, judgments, attachments, or private interpretations.

I would phrase the rule this way:

My inner life is private. Access is intentional, limited, and earned—not extracted through pressure, curiosity, or provocation.

But privacy does not require emotional numbness or complete isolation. You can be warm, courteous, expressive, and collaborative while keeping the deepest part of yourself sovereign. You decide what to share, with whom, for what purpose, and at what time.

A practical pause before disclosure:

1. Why am I sharing this?
2. What purpose does it serve?
3. Is this person trustworthy in this context?
4. Would I be comfortable if this were repeated?
5. Can I share the fact without revealing the emotional button?

The strongest boundary is not appearing unreadable. It is knowing that even when someone observes a reaction, they still do not control what you do next.

Others may see the surface; interpretation and authority remain mine.

Me: What I have found is that the moment people realize they can push my buttons, they will do it because it gives them power. They feel powerful knowing that they can “play” me.

ChatGPT: Yes, some people repeat behavior when they discover it reliably produces a reaction. The reaction becomes a reward: attention, influence, amusement, reassurance, or a temporary sense of control.

But you do not need to determine whether every provocation is deliberate. The same response works either way:

Notice. Pause. Do not reward. Process privately. Choose deliberately.

Stillness is not pretending you feel nothing. It means the feeling does not decide your outward behavior.

A useful internal sequence:

1. **Name it privately:** “I feel irritated.”

2. **Separate fact from interpretation:** “What did they actually say or do?”
3. **Delay:** Do not explain, defend, correct, or retaliate immediately.
4. **Respond only to the practical issue:** Use one neutral sentence—or none.
5. **Record patterns:** One event may be accidental; repetition is information.
6. **Adjust access:** Reduce attention, disclosure, availability, or contact when warranted.

Neutral responses can be very small:

- “Noted.”
- “I’ll consider it.”
- “That’s your view.”
- “What is the specific request?”
- “Let’s stay with the issue.”
- Silence.

The strongest rule is:

No one learns how to direct me through provocation. My emotions are processed privately; my actions remain chosen.

And there is no need to announce this rule. Its effectiveness comes from quietly practicing it.

Me: Now I have a shortcut: “Noise.”

If I become truly irritated, I tell myself, “I will find myself in my stillness.”

If I feel lonely, I remind myself that all happiness originates within me. My positive feelings about another person may be projections, and I may not fully understand their intentions. Then I picture the person in their 80s or 100s, and it would be terrifying to look at them. Now, whenever I see couples, I almost feel sorry for them.

I also value and protect my money, time, and inner peace. Money buys me options, so I now monitor my spending and the “scripts” that trigger it. I delete those scripts.

ChatGPT: Exactly. The underlying rule is:

I do not spend money, time, attention, or peace to obtain approval. My worth is not being evaluated.

Your eyelids reminded you of the difference between **appearance and function**. Redness can feel alarming because appearance is immediately visible, but the deeper reality is that your eyes let you see oceans, glaciers, paintings, flowers, your daughter, and your own life. Gratitude returns attention from cosmetic judgment to capability.

A distilled set of rules:

**My worth is not up for debate.
I am precious and complete as I am.
I do not perform for approval.
My resources protect my freedom.
My body is not an ornament; it carries me through life.
I appreciate what it enables me to experience.**

One small refinement: “never spend to impress” is powerful; spending for education, learning, clothing, photography, or comfort can still be entirely valid when it gives **you** pleasure. The test is simple:

Would I still choose this if nobody else ever saw it?

If yes, it belongs to you rather than to an audience.

Me: Then I need to reevaluate pleasure. Clothing and photography are very valid because they can last a lifetime. I definitely say no to superficial, temporary things that require constant maintenance at great cost and risk harming my natural body in response to insecurity. I trust my body will heal with proper self-care.

ChatGPT: Yes. The question is not whether something gives pleasure, but **what kind of pleasure it creates, what it costs over time, and whether it comes from appreciation or insecurity.**

Clothing and photography can be deeply valid for you because they create durable value:

- A well-chosen garment can last decades, travel with you, and become part of your visual autobiography.
- A photograph preserves how you saw a place and how you existed within it.
- Both can express your own aesthetic even when no one else sees or approves of them.

Your distinction could be:

I invest in what preserves, expresses, or expands my life. I do not repeatedly waste money, energy, and resources to quiet an insecurity.

Before spending, ask:

1. **Origin:** Is this desire coming from delight or inadequacy?
2. **Duration:** Will the value remain after the immediate emotional effect disappears?
3. **Maintenance:** What continuing money, time, and attention will it demand?
4. **Physical cost:** Could it damage or unnecessarily burden my natural body?
5. **Autonomy:** Would I still choose it without comparison, advertising, or an audience?
6. **Optionality:** Does it enrich my life enough to justify the freedom the money could otherwise preserve?

Not everything temporary is superficial—a meal, a concert, or a beautiful day tour may be fleeting but still become part of your life. The real division is not permanent versus temporary. It is:

Chosen experience versus insecurity management.

And for your body:

I am a unicorn—special and beautiful. I protect my health, function, and natural integrity.

Me: Chosen experience versus insecurity management. Eliminate insecurity—it was all created in my mind. What would I possibly complain about if I were 120 years old right now? I would consider myself the most amazing person in the world.

ChatGPT: The 120-year-old perspective is powerful because it changes the reference point. At 120, you would not complain that your eyelids were imperfect or that a photograph caught the wrong angle. You would marvel that you could still see, walk, think, travel, dress yourself, and create photographs.

But notice one remaining external frame in:

“I would be rated the world’s most amazing person.”

You would not need to be rated at all. Your existence would be extraordinary to **you**. The deepest version is:

If I would treasure this body, face, and life at 120, I can treasure them now.

You may not be able to delete every momentary insecurity, but you can refuse to feed, finance, or obey it:

Insecurity may appear, but it receives no money, no decisions, and no authority.

And your spending distinction becomes:

I invest in chosen experiences and lasting expressions. I do not purchase relief from imagined inadequacy.

Your present self already possesses what your 120-year-old self would consider priceless: vision, mobility, independence, time, curiosity, and the ability to experience the world.

What I Hope You Remember

If I could leave you with only a few thoughts, they would be these:

Your worth is not up for debate.

Do not allow provocation to choose your behavior. Pause, process privately, and act deliberately.

Protect your attention, because whatever repeatedly receives your attention gradually shapes your life.

Protect your money, not simply to accumulate it, but because money preserves options, independence, and the ability to leave situations that no longer serve you.

Choose experiences, learning, beauty, and possessions because they genuinely enrich your life—not because you feel inadequate or need to impress an audience.

Appreciate your body for everything it allows you to see, feel, create, and experience. What seems imperfect today may be exactly what your older self would consider priceless.

Most importantly, build happiness within yourself. Other people may accompany you, love you, teach you, or share parts of the journey, but the center of your life remains within you.

These are lessons I am still learning. You will discover your own. I trust you to decide what is true and useful for your life.

You are deeply loved—not for what you achieve, how you look, or what anyone thinks of you, but simply because you are you.